

United Overseas Bank (UOB)

First Take: Credit cost led miss, stock to stay weak

Our First Take: UOB reported 1Q25 net income of S\$1.49bn, flat y/y, down 2% q/q and 4% below JPMe. The miss was due to higher credit costs of 35bps ann. (of which 16bps was GP), which the bank attributed to pre-emptive allowances though NPA coverage was flat at 90%. PPoP met estimates, with NIM holding up better than expected (flat q/q), and non-II delivering a beat with strong loan fees and wealth management in the quarter. Costs were slightly higher, with staff costs moving up 4% q/q, but this was partly in line with better revenues. CET1 ratio ended 1Q flat q/q at 15.4%.

Management paused 2025 guidance given the uncertainty. However, the bank reiterated its commitment to its announced S\$3bn capital distribution plan (S\$2bn buyback over 3Y, 50c special dividend in 2025). The readthrough for DBS and OCBC 1Q is positive as both banks have large WM franchise. NIM resilience at UOB is a surprise, and the outcome at peers may not necessarily be the same, given the sharp decline in SORA (3M down 73bps YTD). We also expect all three banks to reduce/suspend guidance.

Key Positives

NIM held up well, with lower loan margins offset by higher interbank and securities margin. Fee income growth accelerated to 22% q/q, with loan and trade related fees as well as WM driving the strength.

Key Negatives/Question Marks

Costs were higher than expected, with core expenses (ex-Citi integration in 2024) up 6% y/y. Including Citi, costs were down 1% y/y and q/q. The bank booked 35bps ann. credit costs, partly due to pre-emptive allowances due to macro uncertainties.

Likely Changes to Consensus

We expect small downward revisions from the Street, with 1Q accounting for 24% of FY25 estimates.

Expected Stock Reaction

Investors were cautious/short into numbers. NIM resilience may limit sharp downside, but AQ worries can lead to multiples being questioned. In case NIM guidance comes off meaningfully during the briefing, the stock could stay weak.

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Neutral

UOBH.SI, UOB SP

Price (06 May 25): S\$34.98

Price Target (Dec-25): S\$40.00



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Conference call details

UOB is hosting a media briefing today at 9AM HKT and analyst briefing at 10:30AM HKT.

Table 1: UOB: 1Q25 earnings review

P&L (\$mn)	1Q24	2Q24	3Q24	4Q24	1Q25A	1Q25E	YoY	QoQ	JPM
Net Interest Income	2,362	2,401	2,460	2,451	2,409	2,376	2%	-2%	1%
Non-Interest Income	1,161	1,075	1,374	1,010	1,248	1,179	7%	24%	6%
Fee Income	580	618	630	567	694	641	20%	22%	8%
Other Non-Il	581	457	744	443	554	538	-5%	25%	3%
Operating Revenue	3,523	3,476	3,834	3,461	3,657	3,554	4%	6%	3%
Operating Costs	(1,475)	(1,452)	(1,590)	(1,558)	(1,559)	(1,480)	6%	0%	5%
PPOP	2,048	2,024	2,244	1,903	2,098	2,074	2%	10%	1%
Impairment Charge	(170)	(238)	(311)	(235)	(297)	(224)	75%	26%	33%
Other Income	26	30	25	40	22	32	-15%	-45%	-31%
Pre-Tax	1,904	1,816	1,958	1,708	1,823	1,882	-4%	7%	-3%
Core profit	1,566	1,488	1,638	1,540	1,490	1,569	-5%	-3%	-5%
Non-Recurring Items	(79)	(64)	(28)	(17)	-	(15)	-100%	-100%	-100%
Reported profit	1,487	1,424	1,610	1,523	1,490	1,554	0%	-2%	-4%
DPS (\$)	-	0.88	-	1.17	-	-	NM	-100%	NM
Gross Loans	322,634	327,600	333,998	337,831	341,154	344,620	6%	1%	-1%
Deposits	388,472	389,157	400,784	403,978	401,250	406,184	3%	-1%	-1%
NPL	4,840	4,888	4,852	5,164	5,458	5,333	13%	6%	2%
NPA	5,051	4,952	5,055	5,210	5,361	5,379	6%	3%	0%
Total Allowances	4,993	4,851	5,026	4,764	4,829	4,859	-3%	1%	-1%
Change in bps									
NIM	2.02%	2.05%	2.05%	2.00%	2.00%	1.96%	(2)	0	4
CIR	41.9%	41.8%	41.5%	45.0%	42.6%	41.6%	76	(239)	99
LDR	83.1%	84.2%	83.3%	83.6%	85.0%	84.8%	197	140	18
CASA Ratio	50.6%	51.5%	53.6%	54.6%	55.1%	54.9%	450	48	24
Credit Costs (bps)	23	24	34	25	35	26	12	10	9
NPL Ratio	1.50%	1.49%	1.45%	1.53%	1.60%	1.55%	10	7	5
NPA Coverage	99%	98%	99%	91%	90%	90%	(900)	(100)	(34)
CET1 (fully phased-in)	13.9%	13.4%	15.2%	15.4%	15.4%	14.9%	154	2	47

Source: Company reports, J.P. Morgan estimates.

Investment Thesis, Valuation and Risks

United Overseas Bank (UOB) *(Neutral; Price Target: S\$40.00)*

Investment Thesis

We are N on UOB.

- UOB has delivered RoE with the least volatility among Singapore banks over the past 20 years. We expect that trend to sustain over the medium-term. We expect over 13% ROE in next 2Y, driven by a combination of buyback and a focus on cost management, along with sector-high loan growth (~7%). However, the shift in rate outlook could lead to lower NIM, which would be a drag.
- Management's commitment to 14-14.5% CET1 by 2027 provides visibility on the capital return. This follows the increase in fully phased-in CET1 to 15.2% following Basel IV implementation, which increased the bank's capacity to return capital. We expect S\$1.5bn buyback in 2025 and S\$1bn in 2026.
- The Citi acquisition is an important driver of RoE as the bank gets through a phase of investments in 2023-24. UOB's acquisition of Citi assets in Thailand, Indonesia, Malaysia and Vietnam added 3% to loans, 5% to AUM, and ~5% to EPS in steady state.
- Following increased spend in the last 2Y, we expect cost control to be a focus, supporting efficiency improvements.
- We believe valuations appear fair at 10.0x/1.30x 2025E PE/PB, with a 6% yield. We expect the ROE trajectory and capital management to drive the stock.

Valuation

Our Dec-25 PT of S\$40 is based on a fair P/B of 1.21x with a normalized RoE of 12.4%, a risk-free rate of 4.5%, a cost of capital of 10.3% and a growth rate of 0.5%.

Risks to Rating and Price Target

Downside risks include worse-than-expected asset quality, growth and NIM disappointment, and lower-than-expected dividends and buyback. Sustained higher operating costs would also be a downside risk. Higher-than-anticipated digital investment spending could be a drag on profitability.

Upside risks include sustained delivery on RoE, cost management post investments in 2023-24, and higher dividend. On PPoP, the bank's ability to manage early wins from its digital investments could lead to positive revisions, and investments coming to fruition earlier than anticipated would pose upside risks on costs.

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United Overseas Bank (UOB) (UOBH.SI, UOB SP) Price Chart



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Sep 24, 2002. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

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